It is likely that I shall go to Tehran shortly altho this is not certain. Whether I shall be able to get any thing done about my affairs is uncertain. I suspect the Hadji[100] does not like me.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, March 27, 1846*

How does trade go with you? Pray do not fail to let me know when you write. The trade here is a very different one from that at Tabreez. The latter is a great mart for the surrounding countries. This not so much so, altho it is situated in the line of the great route between Arabia and Tartary yet its transit trade is comparatively speaking trifling. The most lucrative trade I know of here, altho certainly not the most respectable, is usury: lending money chiefly on pledges chiefly jewels and shawls at 20, 30, 50, and sometimes to my knowledge 120 pr Cent pr annm! and this, that is, for the lower rates of interest 20 or 30% pr anm for no small sums. The governor of the province of Fars (Persia proper) when last here borrowed about thirty thousand pounds at this rate most of which I believe he has now paid. This money was I believe borrowed without pledges but the usual way is when the amount is only a few thousands or less to take pledges for about double the sum lent. Much money has been made in this during the last twelve years in Tehran, but the commerce is not thought respectable and I fancy (forgive my superstition) that there is a curse attending on it.

The trade of the Greeks at Tabreez is not nearly so good as it has been and for some time back the principals have not been getting much profit; of course the houses at Tabreez which are only agency do not loose [sic] but I suspect the owners of the goods have had some losses lately.

A few days ago I received news of the death of a friend of mine, Capn Todd,[101] poor fellow his head was carried of[f] by a cannon shot at the great battle fought on the banks of the Sutledge last December. He was an officer of the Bengal Horse Artillery and many years in Persia; well read, clever and accomplished, pity such men should be made food for gunpowder. — The last news we had of this victory was only a few days after the battle was fought, there appears to have been much mismanagement, and consequently an unnecessary loss of life but I suppose, that to take Gwalior, as it was a victory, no one will be blamed.

*Tehran, March 27, 1846*

I wrote you a few hurried lines before leaving Tabreez and now send you this chiefly to inform you of my safe arrival and good health for I have little other news to give you. I presented my book on China to the Shah in person;

100 The Prime Minister.

101 The British Army List for 1845–1847 does not list a Bengal Horse Artillery, probably because it was composed of natives.

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